effective civilian-military collaboration and formulation of policy. It explains in part the increasing US influence on Israeli decisions, particularly on the priority given to hostage release over the launch of a ground operation against Hamas.

Incidentally, Netanyahu's future line of defense was confirmed in an interview given to Channel 14, the mouthpiece of the Likud, by cabinet member Miri Regev, the prime minister's most faithful follower. When asked about the PM's responsibility for October 7, she replied that the prime minister cannot dismiss the head of Shin Bet, the head of Mossad, or the chief of Military Intelligence; they are the specialists, they offer the assessments. Netanyahu may try, but he will be forced to resign.

Two female hostages were released today: one aged eighty-five, the other eighty. They were brought in ambulances, on stretchers.

Notwithstanding my dislike for Netanyahu and my desire to see him out of the door, at the moment I prefer his prudence to Gallant's insistence on a ground operation in Gaza and, earlier, on an immediate offensive against Hezbollah. A ground operation in Gaza could be disastrous, since Hamas has dug miles of tunnels that would take months to clear and result in a considerable number of casualties on all sides. During that time, growing international pressure would be exerted on Israel, demanding an end to the Gaza warfare. After a while, the US would probably have to join these demands. In a declaration he made today, ex-president Obama seemed to adopt such an attitude. And, as horrendous as this would sound to most Israeli ears, Hamas could then strut and fret and claim victory.

Tuesday, October 24

The Israeli chief of staff repeated that the army was ready for a ground operation, but the decision is not his, as we know; it depends on Netanyahu and the Americans. Iran-supported groups have fired rockets targeting